

Case Study: Inappropriate Use of Surveys

1. The Cambridge Analytica scandal (2018)

In 2018, it emerged that the political consultancy Cambridge Analytica had obtained data about tens of millions of Facebook users through a harmless personality-quiz app. Only a small number of users installed the app, yet the design of Facebook's interface at the time allowed the app to pull profile data not only from those users but also from their friends. This created an exceptionally large dataset without most people ever realising their information had been captured.

The firm then used these data to build psychographic profiles and to support targeted political advertising in elections and referendum campaigns. Many users believed they had taken part in a simple quiz. The survey front-end concealed a complex pipeline of profiling, prediction, and political influence.

Key issues:

- Data were collected under vague and technical consent screens that most users did not understand.
- Friends™ data were harvested without any direct interaction with the survey.
- Survey responses were combined with other personal information to infer personality traits and political views.
- The same data were reused for purposes far beyond users™ reasonable expectations, including election campaigning.

2. Example 2: TikTok personality tests and youth data

Reports about TikTok and third-party tools around it has raised similar concerns about opaque data practices. Short quizzes and filters aimed at entertainment often sit on top of tracking technologies that log viewing patterns, interactions, and biometric information such as facial features. Young users, who form a large part of the TikTok audience, may treat these features as games but still provide a steady flow of rich personal data.

Legal complaints and commentary have argued that data about children and teenagers have been gathered and processed without clear explanation, and that information about how long data are kept, who can access them and for what purposes is difficult to locate or interpret. This raises questions about whether consent can be considered informed, especially for minors.

Key issues:

- Privacy notices are long, legalistic, and poorly matched to an incredibly young user base.
- Data, including potential biometric information, can be shared with third parties for advertising and analytics.
- Children may not recognise that a quiz is also a data-collection tool.
- There is a risk that profiles created from these data follow users across platforms and over time.

3. Example 3: Phishing surveys and fake reward schemes

Phishing campaigns often use fake surveys to lure people into handing over sensitive data. Messages arrive by email, text, or social media, claiming to be from a well-known retailer, bank, or delivery company. The recipient is invited to complete an escort satisfaction survey in exchange for a gift card, a discount, or a small free product.

Once on the survey page, victims are asked to provide contact details, login credentials, or card information, sometimes framed as a small shipping fee. Attackers capture these details and use them for fraud, identity theft, or further targeted frauds. Even when the survey itself looks genuine, the domain or payment processor is controlled by criminals.

Key issues:

- People are encouraged to lower their guard by the promise of a reward.
- Surveys collect far more information than legitimate feedback forms would require.
- The data go directly to attackers, who may combine them with other breached datasets.
- Victims can suffer direct monetary loss and long-term damage to credit and reputation.

4. Impacts and analysis

Perspective	Impacts
Ethical	Misuse of surveys undermines informed consent and respect for persons. People are not told clearly what is being collected, how it will be used or who will see it. Profiling for political or commercial gain without genuine understanding breaches duties of honesty and care.
Social	These cases weaken public trust in online surveys, research projects, and digital platforms. Citizens may withdraw from legitimate studies that inform policy and improve services. Targeted messaging based on hidden profiling can also polarise public debate and limit exposure to diverse views.
Legal	Practices like those seen in the Cambridge Analytica case can conflict with data protection principles such as lawfulness, fairness, transparency, and purpose limitation. Regulators have responded with investigations, fines and, in some jurisdictions, legal settlements. Phishing surveys can also breach criminal law covering fraud and unauthorised access.
Professional	Researchers, data scientists, and marketers are expected to follow professional codes that stress integrity, respect for privacy and avoidance of harm. Inappropriate survey use damages the reputation of these professions and highlights the need for stronger internal governance, ethics review, and accountability mechanisms.

5. Conclusion

These examples show that surveys are not neutral tools. When questionnaires, quizzes or feedback forms are used without clear consent, transparency, and respect for participants, they can become mechanisms for surveillance, manipulation, and fraud. For students and practitioners in computing and data-driven fields, several lessons follow:

- Collect only the data that are genuinely needed for a clearly defined purpose.
- Explain survey aims, data flows and retention periods in language that the target audience can understand.
- Avoid secondary uses of data that fall outside what participants could anticipate.
- Build checks, audits and ethics review into projects that involve large-scale survey or platform data.

Applying these principles supports not only legal compliance but also public trust in digital research and data-driven services.

References

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